

The iMac: Worth a Bite

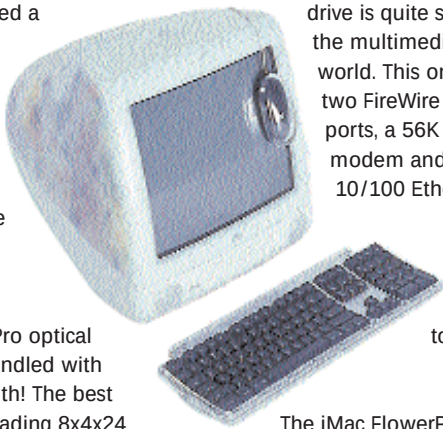
This iMac's been around for three years and nobody has been able to re-create the magic Apple did to computer design. But even the best isn't always the most complete. The iMac looked beautiful, offered a decent performance, included loads of built-in goodies, but still lacked a few basic things such as the ability to transfer files to your friend's non-net-worked PC without adding any extra components such as an external CD Writer or zip disk, and not to forget the beautiful but irritating round mouse. The new iMac fixes all this.

It comes with the Apple Pro optical mouse, similar to the one bundled with the new G4 machines. Smooth! The best addition is the built-in slot loading 8x4x24

CD-RW drive. Just pop in a rewritable CD, dump a few files, and walk to the horizon happily—no hassles with a non-existent floppy drive, no extra money to be spent in order to add another storage device.

Even the enormous 40 GB hard drive is quite sufficient for the multimedia-rich Mac world. This one includes two FireWire ports, two USB ports, a 56K v.90 fax modem and a RJ45 10/100 Ethernet port.

The built-in ATi RAGE 128 Ultra graphics accelerator with 16 MB



The iMac FlowerPower

of SDRAM is capable of pumping out a maximum usable resolution of 1024x768 at 75 Hz on the built-in 15-inch monitor. On the base, you would see two tiny but crisp and powerful Harman Kardon speakers, quiet similar to the two that came with the now discontinued PowerMac G4 Cube.

The model we received came with a 600 MHz PowerPC G3 processor with 128 MB of RAM expandable to 1 GB of RAM. It came pre-bundled with Mac OS 9.1, and OS-X, where OS 9.1 is pre-installed. Loads of other goodies such as iMovie 2, iTunes, AppleWorks and quite a few games and utilities also came bundled along with this.

Overall, a sturdy, all-in-one, useable Mac that comes to Indian homes at around twice the price it sells for in the US.

respectively, making it a worthy choice for the casual gamer.

For users who are interested in good quality sound, the Minicomp iSystem is the ideal PC featuring a Lancer 4 point surround soundcard and a DVD-ROM drive. This makes it quite suitable for home entertainment. Another machine worthy of consideration by MP3 fans is the Amdell Powerhouse 1000, featuring the Athlon 1 GHz, which completed audio ripping in 35 seconds flat, followed closely by Visualan Lavish P4 which took 36 seconds. If you encode a lot of MP3s, these systems are pretty good choices.

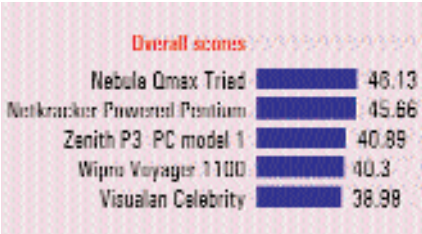
For users whose primary job on a PC includes data-intensive applica-

tions, the **Amdell Workhorse 850** took the cake with the highest sequential write speed of 39 MBps. Another point in its favour is its price at Rs 37,500. Other PCs for these users are both the machines of Visualan with scores of 38 MBps and the Vintron Biz 123 1000 with a score of 37 MBps.

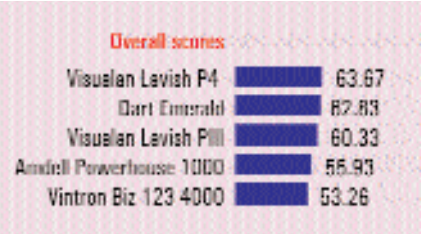
Users looking at a PC for office productivity and performance will be satisfied with the **Visualan Lavish P4** with a score of 35.2 in Content Creation Winstone 2000. Visualan Lavish PIII once again trailed it closely with a score of 34.4.



The Compaq Presario 5000 comes with JBL Platinum speakers and a Web cam



The top five scorers in the Content Creation test among the Budget systems



The top five scorers in the Content Creation test among the Midrange systems

Dart Emerald, Dart Marvel and Amdell Workhorse 850 delivered a reasonable performance in the ZD Content Creation test with scores of 33.1, 32.7 and 30.6 respectively. These PCs offer a good price-performance combination.

Any PC with an Intel 815 chipset-based motherboard, 64 MB RAM and a Pentium III 700 and above processor would generate a score in the range of 25 to 30 in Content Creation. This score can be referred to as an above average score. For the same configuration, if a machine generates a score below the average, then it is definitely not worth the investment, especially if you plan to use it for office applications.

A majority of the PCs in this category shipped with 15-inch monitors. For those interested more in graphics-oriented applications, a 17-inch monitor would definitely make a world of a difference. For these users, Amdell Powerhouse 1000, Vintron Biz 123 4000 and Visualan Lavish P4 had 17-inch monitors. In fact, Zenith Multimedia PC model 1 and 2 had identical configurations, barring the monitor.

As Internet and electronic communication in the form of e-mail, chat and Internet Telephony has become one of the primary reasons why users buy a PC, all the PCs had fax modems, either internal or external. This helps users get online as soon as they receive a PC.